FOR THE CxO TEAM OF AN IT SERVICES FIRM

AI engineering tools for a services practice

A separate trial of Devin and of Synlynk, scored on whether the firm's existing delivery SOPs survive.

Decision. Trial Devin on legacy modernization, managed application services, and accompanied time-and-materials work, with the firm's peer review, change control, and a usage cap in the statement of work. Trial Synlynk on one dedicated product-engineering pod, or on one regulated on-premises pilot locked to a local model, with unattended execution turned off. Do not put either tool into a multi-account factory or an outcome-based contract yet. Synlynk is not ready for one firm's teams to deploy it across many customers. The two products are separate trials.

Panel: Agy, Codex (gpt-5.6-luna), and Grok, convened 19 October 2026 through Synlynk's decide runner. Claude was invited and could not sit because its CLI was on a weekly limit. Codex's configured model, gpt-5.6-terra, was at capacity. Record dec-85a5a151. The decide tool stamps that record approved when it writes. This brief is the panel's recommendation, not an operator sign-off.

How to read the scores

The score is fitness for keeping the firm's current practice, not a rating of model quality. Five means estimation, the staffing pyramid, peer review, change control, status reporting, knowledge transfer, client IP assignment, and reuse of accelerators can stay as they are. One means the tool forces the firm to abandon those SOPs.

The working score is the panel synthesis. The range is the three members. A wide range is a split opinion, not a measurement. Vendor case studies, including Nubank, Comarch, Mercedes-Benz, Endava, Cognizant, and Infosys, are the vendor's account of the result. The panel was told not to treat those multiples as audited.

What each trial is

Devin is an autonomous software engineer from Cognition. A session plans, edits, tests, and opens a pull request from Cloud, Desktop, or CLI. Enterprise buyers get SAML or OIDC, SOC 2 Type II since September 2024, and a contract metered in Agent Compute Units. The machine can sit in Cognition's cloud, in a dedicated VPC, or in the customer's VPC. In the documented dedicated model the reasoning tier can still run in Cognition's cloud. Public services-firm use already includes Cognizant, Infosys, Endava, WPP Enterprise Solutions, and AHEAD. Cognition staffs partner-deployed engineers for global systems integrators. The published Japan split matches a services firm: accompany the client's own team, or use Devin on the firm's contracted delivery.

Synlynk is a host-local control plane. It sends a task to a harness the firm already runs, including Claude, Codex, Grok, Agy, or a local model. The harness works in its own git worktree and can edit, test, and open a pull request. The product scans a workspace, can classify a directory of repositories, builds a cross-repo graph, requires a different party to review, and records cost against the job. It does not operate a multi-tenant cloud. The personal relay moves events between the operator's own devices. A model call still leaves the host unless the local harness is selected. A 16 October 2026 architecture review, which the panel was required to use, found that unattended scheduling does not consistently demand approval before work starts, and that a job's recorded status can diverge from GitHub.

Engagement patterns

Working score, then the member range as Devin / Synlynk.

Pattern	Devin	Synlynk	Range	What happens to the SOP
T&M staff augmentation	**4**	**3**	2–5 / 2–4	Devin can sit beside a named team. One member scored it 2 because an autonomous seat bypasses the pyramid. Synlynk fits when it follows a named engineer and unattended scheduling stays off.

Pattern	Devin	Synlynk	Range	What happens to the SOP
Fixed-price project	**3**	**2**	2–4 / 2–3	Neither meter is a person-day. A usage cap in the statement of work is the control. Synlynk’s status gap weakens earned-value reporting.
Managed application services	**4**	**2**	3–4 / 2–3	Devin Oncall and ticket links resemble a run-state queue. Synlynk has no service-desk connector, and a status that can disagree with GitHub is weak SLA evidence.
Legacy modernization	**4**	**3**	3–5 / 2–4	The Devin trial the whole panel will support, with the firm’s review gate kept. Synlynk’s repo graph has no published program at this scale.
Dedicated product-engineering pod	**4**	**4**	3–5 / 4–4	The pattern where every member scores Synlynk at 4 or above. Roles, a worktree per job, and a non-author review match a pod’s definition of done.
Multi-account factory	**3**	**2**	2–4 / 2–2	Unanimous that Synlynk cannot carry one playbook across accounts. There is no tenant boundary. Devin’s tenancy is further along and is still not a factory SOP.
Advisory, then implementation	**4**	**3**	3–4 / 2–3	Devin’s codebase reading supports discovery that becomes a build. Synlynk’s workspace scan supports an audit.
Regulated, on the client’s premises	**2**	**4**	2–2 / 3–4	Devin is unanimous at 2. The synthesis scores Synlynk 4. Two members scored 3, because a cloud harness still sends the prompt out. Use 4 only when the pilot is locked to a local model.
Outcome-based or gainshare	**2**	**2**	2–3 / 2–3	Both meters record compute. Neither records the client outcome the contract pays on. Keep this pattern out of the first trials.

Where the existing SOP holds

Peer review and change control hold when the firm keeps them in the statement of work. Devin’s pull request is the input to the firm’s review. Synlynk already separates the reviewer from the author, which is why the pod is the Synlynk trial.

Estimation holds only as a capped envelope. Person-day rates do not describe Agent Compute Units or harness tokens. Price a discovery fee plus a usage ceiling, and stop the pilot when the ceiling is hit.

The staffing pyramid holds on accompanied time-and-materials and on a named pod. It weakens if the tool is staffed as a headcount substitute. That is the warning inside the low Devin score on staff augmentation. Cognition’s accompany model is the shape that keeps the firm’s people in the engagement.

Knowledge transfer holds when the firm leaves the client with the runbook, the review record, and the cost record. Synlynk’s ledger is built for that handback on a single host. Devin’s session history lives with the vendor unless the contract says otherwise.

Client IP holds in the contract either way. For Synlynk it holds technically when the harness is local, and it needs a written egress rule when the harness is a cloud model. For Devin it needs the deployment schedule in the order form, because a customer VPC does not by itself place the reasoning tier in that VPC.

Status reporting holds for Devin through the ticket tools a managed-service desk already uses. It does not yet hold for Synlynk, because the job record and GitHub can disagree. A delivery manager should take the steerco status from GitHub.

SWOT

Devin

Strengths. The product is an engineer a client can watch: shell, editor, browser, parallel sessions, review, and on-call. Procurement has a path: SOC 2 Type II, SAML or OIDC, a sales contract, and marketplace routes. Services firms are already on the record, and Cognition is hiring people whose job is to make those firms successful. Ticket and chat assignment matches a managed-service queue.

Weaknesses. The usage meter does not match a person-day estimate or a fixed-price baseline. In the dedicated deployment the reasoning tier can remain in Cognition’s cloud, so a residency claim is incomplete until the order form is read. An autonomous session will ignore the staffing pyramid unless the statement of work names the firm’s reviewers and forbids an unattended merge.

Opportunities. One modernization account and one accompanied time-and-materials account are enough to learn the offer. Partner-deployed engineers let the firm build a repeatable playbook. Managed service is the second commercial pattern, because on-call and ticket links resemble work the firm already staffs.

Threats. Client code and prompts meet a vendor-operated brain. Direct sales compete with the partner for the same logo. Unit cost moves with the model and the session length, so an uncapped commitment inside a fixed fee is a margin leak. A published multiple the firm cannot reproduce on its own scope becomes a renewal problem.

Synlynk

Strengths. The firm runs it on a host it controls and chooses the engineer per task, including a local model. Each job is isolated in a worktree. A different party reviews. Cost is recorded against the job. Roles give a pod a place to put the responsibilities it already has. The workspace scan and the cross-repo graph are a real start on understanding an account before anyone codes.

Weaknesses. Unattended execution is not a safe default. Job status can diverge from GitHub, so a PMO cannot trust the dashboard. Each repository still has its own workspace identity, and the context a job receives comes from that repository’s graph, not from the merged map of the account. There is no systems-integrator kit, no service-desk connector, and no published result on a multi-million-line estate. The sharper gap than a missing SOC 2 report is the absence of a fail-closed local-only mode.

Opportunities. A single product pod can adopt it without throwing away sprint review. A regulated account that already forbids code from leaving the building is the other honest pilot, and only with the local harness. The longer opportunity is the layer the firm’s existing teams operate across accounts: policy, evidence, and cost, with whichever coding agent the client already bought.

Threats. Turning the scheduler on across clients before approval and tenancy exist can breach change control and mix one client’s material into another’s context. A cloud harness quietly defeats a residency promise. Pursuit teams will reject a tool that cannot show an audit pack or a bid sheet in the firm’s current formats.

This quarter

1. Devin. One modernization slice or one accompanied time-and-materials team. The statement of work keeps the firm’s peer review and change control, names who may merge, and caps Agent Compute Units.

2. Synlynk. One dedicated pod, or one regulated on-premises slice locked to the local harness. Unattended scheduling stays off. Steerco status comes from GitHub, not from the job label.

3. One scorecard for both. Cycle time, escaped defects, review compliance, gross margin after the meter, and any client-IP incident. Do not sign a factory rollout or a gainshare from either result.

Limits of this review

The panel is three harnesses. Claude did not participate. Members disagreed by two or more points on staff augmentation, fixed price, modernization, the factory, and regulated delivery. Those ranges are in the table so a synthesized number is not mistaken for consensus. The evidence was the public Devin record as of 19 October 2026 and an inspection of the Synlynk repository, including the 16 October architecture review. No client pilot was run for this brief. The companion roadmap gap analysis is docs/retrospectives/2026-10-19-synlynk-it-services-deployment-gap-analysis.md.